accurately reflect liver health. "Ten per cent of liver transplants are performed on individuals who have had over 70 per cent of their liver destroyed, yet their liver function tests remain normal," he says. Thus, many have a fatty liver without being aware of it. And any measure of fat above 5 per cent, even for a short duration, can be harmful to your health. "Fatty liver is the cause of a number of health issues such as hypertension, diabetes, thyroid issues, cancers; they can even cause heart attacks. It is crucial to maintain a healthy liver," says Dr Sarin.

In 2021, India became the first country to declare NAFLD a non-communicable disease. Three years later, in October 2024, the Union ministry of health and family welfare introduced fresh guidelines for preventing and treating the disease. "NAFLD is rapidly emerging as a major public health concern, closely linked with metabolic disorders such as obesity, diabetes and cardiovascular diseases. Three out of 10 people can have NAFLD, which highlights the impact of the disease," says Apurva Chandra, former Union health secretary.

WHY A HEALTHY LIVER MATTERS

While the liver is most commonly known for filtering impurities from our blood, there are in fact more than 500 vital functions that have been linked with the organ. All the blood leaving the digestive tract passes through the liver, which breaks down, balances and produces nutrients for the body to use. The liver also either throws out toxins or metabolises them into a form that the body can use. At any given point of time, the liver holds at least 13 per cent of the body's blood supply.

Among some of its lesser-known functions is its ability to regulate blood clotting, conversion of excess glucose in our blood to glycogen for storage and flushing out cholesterol from the body. "The liver is actually the largest immune gland in our body," says Dr Sarin. According to varying studies, the organ accounts for nearly 25-50 per cent of the lymph which passes through the lymphatic system—a part of the immune system that keeps the body fluid level in check and defends against infections. The liver also directly produces immune cells. "The liver is an immunologically complex organ, responsible for the production of acute phase proteins, complement components, cytokines and chemokines, and contains large, diverse populations of resident immune cells," explains Dr Rajesh Chandra, consultant, gastroenterology, Manipal Hospital, Vijayawada. In short, it is an organ that multi-tasks tirelessly.

The liver is also a unique organ because of its capacity to repair and regenerate itself. It can actually regrow to its normal size even after up to 90 per cent of it has been removed or damaged. This is also the reason why insults to the organ, such as alcohol, disease, certain toxic drugs and excess or unbalanced dietary calories, take longer to manifest as the liver keeps repairing itself. "The liver is constantly bombarded by a stream of dietary and commensal bacterial products with inflammatory potential in healthy individuals. Inflamma-

MIND YOUR LIVER

It can withstand much damage and still regenerate itself. But pushed beyond all limit, this vital organ just might start to give up

WHAT IS THE LIVER?

- A crucial part of our digestive system, this one gland performs more than 500 biological functions. All the blood leaving our stomach and intestines passes through it to be purified and detoxified; it holds about 13% of our blood supply at any given time. With an amazing ability to repair and regenerate itself, the liver can regrow anywhere up to its normal size even after up to 90% of it has been removed or damaged

WHAT DOES IT DO?

- Helps produce bile, which breaks down fats in the small intestine during digestion. Bile byproducts exit the body in the form of faeces
- Aids production of cholesterol and special proteins to carry fats through our body
- Converts excess glucose into glycogen for storage and later use. Also balances level of blood glucose in the body
- Clears the blood of drugs, poisonous substances, breaking them down into non-toxic forms. The kidneys filter the blood byproducts which leave the body in the form of urine
- Regulates blood clotting
- Removes bacteria from the body and helps us resist infections. The liver is the largest immune gland in our body



"Run an awareness campaign every 15 days: eat when hungry; **snacking is not a solution for loneliness or insecurity; choose whole foods; stop when 80% full; start meal with a glass of water** followed by raw salads; drink water first whenever you feel hungry, false hunger disappears"

–DR YOGESH CHAWLA *Former Director and Head, Department of Hepatology, PGIMER, Chandigarh*